Operation Zugzwang — Scenario Brief

The public situation, for both teams

All countries, people, and events in this scenario are fictional. All military systems are real U.S. systems, described with unclassified, approximate capabilities.

1. Bottom line up front

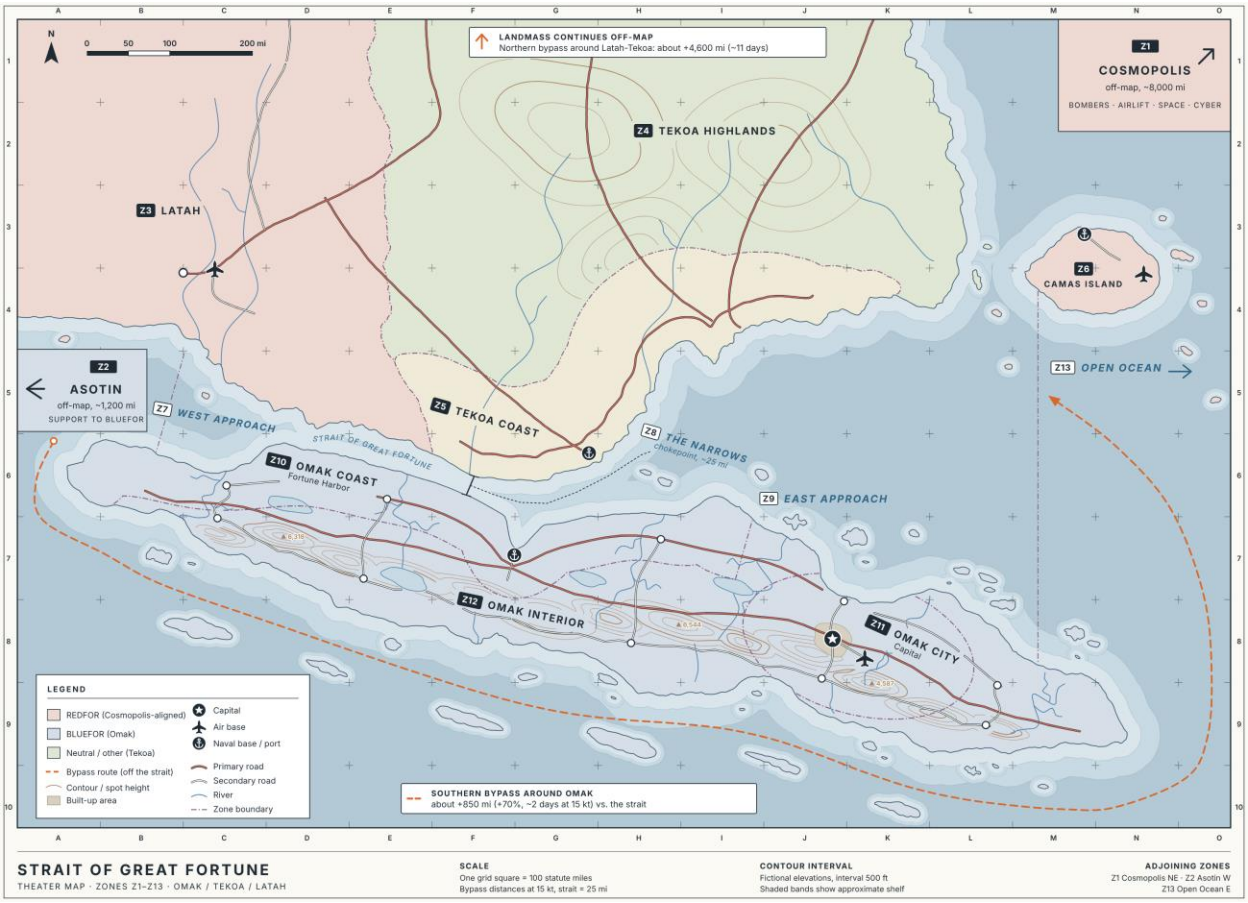
- **REDFOR = Cosmopolis**, a distant, rich, powerful, technologically advanced nation that calls itself a democracy with an apolitical military (the Cosmopolis National Defense Forces, **CNDF**). It is about **8,000 miles northeast** of the conflict.
- **BLUEFOR = Omak.** An election scandal (revealed Cosmopolis backing of the Sapphire Party president) and wider discontent triggered an uprising. The apolitical **National Democratic Forces (NDF)** stood aside and let the **People's Freedom Alliance (PFA)**, the armed wing of the **Indigo Party**, take power.
- The **Strait of Great Fortune**, a major trade chokepoint **25–75 miles wide**, is bounded by **Omak to the south** and **Tekoa to the north**.
- Cosmopolis had trade deals and a defense treaty with the ousted Sapphire president, who **fled to Cosmopolis**.
- **Asotin**, a peer adversary of Cosmopolis, **backs the PFA government in Omak**.
- **Balance.** REDFOR starts with **more assets**. BLUEFOR has **natural advantages**: it is defending its own land, it has a **supportive population**, and it can **receive support from Asotin**.
- **All assets are American.** Every asset in the game is a real U.S. military system, mostly **Department of the Air Force**. In-world, Omak's NDF bought its U.S.-type equipment from Cosmopolis under the old treaty. For Asotin it is simply a game convention.

2. Background and timeline

Game dates are relative: **D-Day** is the day the war begins.

When	Event
~D−10 years	Cosmopolis and Omak (then governed by the Sapphire Party) sign a **trade agreement** and a **mutual defense treaty**. Cosmopolis gains preferential port access on the Strait and equips Omak's NDF with Cosmopolis-made (U.S.-type) systems.
D−6 months	Omak presidential election. The Sapphire incumbent narrowly wins.
D−4 months	Leaked documents show **Cosmopolis covertly funded and advised the Sapphire campaign**. Protests spread, fueled by existing anger over inflation, unemployment, and corruption.
D−3 months	The PFA seizes government buildings in the capital, **Omak City**. The **NDF's leadership declares neutrality** and does not resist. The Sapphire president **flees to Cosmopolis**.
D−2 months	The PFA-backed Indigo government is sworn in. Cosmopolis refuses to recognize it and calls the takeover a coup. **Asotin recognizes the new government** and offers support.
D−3 weeks	The Indigo government announces it will "review" all Sapphire-era agreements, including Cosmopolis's port access and the defense treaty. Asotin cargo flights begin arriving in Omak. Cosmopolis reinforces its forward air base on **Camas**.
D−3 days (**Phase I**)	Crisis peak. Cosmopolis demands guarantees of free passage. The PFA moves patrol boats and missile batteries to the Strait coast. Both sides posture. **Phase I play happens here.**
D-Day	The white cell's kickoff inject.

3. Map



Counters go in **zones**. There is no hex grid. The Strait of Great Fortune is **25–75 miles wide**. Its four sea zones (Z7, Z8, Z9, Z13) are parts of the Strait, from west to east.

Zone	Name	Notes
Z1	Cosmopolis (off-map box)	REDFOR home: bombers, airlift, space, cyber, reserves
Z2	Asotin (off-map box)	Omak's backer, white-cell controlled. The source of outside support for BLUEFOR.
Z3	Latah	Pro-Cosmopolis. Air bases. **Combat basing not yet granted.**
Z4	Tekoa Highlands	Mountains. Good radar and SOF terrain. Tribes and gangs.
Z5	Tekoa Coast	North shore of the Strait. Pirate havens.
Z6	Camas Island	Pro-Cosmopolis. **CNDF forward air base.**
Z7	West Approach	The western Strait, toward Latah. Asotin supplies reach Omak this way.
Z8	The Narrows	The middle of the Strait and its **narrowest point (~25 mi)**. The chokepoint.
Z9	East Approach	The eastern Strait, toward Camas
Z10	Omak Coast	Fortune Harbor (major port). Coastal missile sites.
Z11	Omak City (Capital)	Seat of government, main NDF air base, Patriot umbrella
Z12	Omak Interior	Reserve bases, dispersal areas
Z13	Open Ocean (map edge)	Naval approach routes beyond the Strait

Key distances

From → To	Distance	Why it matters
Strait length (West to East Approach)	~120 mi	
Strait width	**25–75 mi**	Narrow enough that weapons on either shore reach most of it
The Narrows, width	~25 mi (the narrowest point)	Inside Omak's coastal anti-ship missile range. Mineable.
Camas → The Narrows	~250 mi	Fighters need tanker support for persistence.
Omak Coast → Camas	~250 mi (~400 km)	Close enough that Camas would be exposed to any long-range missiles Omak has
Latah → The Narrows	~300 mi	An alternate or dispersal base (ACE) if Latah agrees
Omak City (Capital) → Omak Coast	~80 mi	
Asotin → Omak	~1,200 mi	Close enough to supply Omak by sea and air
Cosmopolis → theater	~8,000 mi	Long reinforcement timelines (§7)

4. Actors

4.1 Cosmopolis — REDFOR (player team)

Dimension	Situation
Political	Claims to be democratic, with an apolitical military. Hosts the exiled Sapphire president. The exposure of the election meddling is a domestic and international embarrassment, and its legislature is divided over war. Cosmopolis recognizes the exiled president as Omak's legitimate leader and frames intervention as honoring the defense treaty.
Military	Extremely large, well-armed, and advanced. It projects power 8,000 miles from home, relying on the Camas forward base, airlift, tankers, space, and long-range bombers. It knows Omak's equipment well because it sold most of it.
Economic	Wealthy, with trade deals with the Sapphire government. A major share of its regional trade moves through the Strait, so closure means price spikes at home.
Social	Populous. The public is weary of distant wars. Casualties and civilian-harm stories erode support fast.
Information	Has a global media reach, but its credibility is damaged by the meddling scandal.
Infrastructure	Camas Air Base: one large, well-equipped base with limited hardening. Rights in Latah cover logistics only.

4.2 Omak — BLUEFOR (player team: one team, a house divided)

Dimension	Situation
Political	The Indigo Party governs, with its armed wing, the PFA, holding power. The Sapphire Party is ousted, and its leader is in Cosmopolis. Asotin backs the new government. Cosmopolis and its allies contest the government's legitimacy, but it is popular at home after the meddling revelations.
Military	The NDF is the professional, apolitical military that allowed the takeover. The PFA is a partisan militia. The NDF fields U.S.-type equipment bought from Cosmopolis, so spare parts are a long-term worry that Asotin is helping to cover. NDF and PFA have separate chains of command and mutual distrust. A small minority of NDF officers quietly remain Sapphire loyalists.
Economic	A major trade hub on the Strait. Port fees and Fortune Harbor are the state's main income, so a long closure hurts Omak too. Asotin credit lines soften the blow.
Social	Dissatisfaction with the old government drove the uprising, and **the population supports the defense of the country**. Nationalist feeling runs high against foreign interference. Civilians volunteer as militia, lookouts, and laborers.
Information	The PFA controls state media, and the meddling leak is its best propaganda weapon.
Infrastructure	Fortune Harbor port, the main air base near Omak City (the capital), a coastal road network, an early-warning radar chain, and dispersal sites in the interior.

BLUEFOR factions. The one BLUEFOR team plays all three. They shape its internal decision-making.

Faction	Wants	Notes
Indigo Party (government)	To survive, gain legitimacy, and renegotiate the Strait on Omak's terms	The political masters
PFA (Indigo armed wing)	To defend the revolution and destroy Sapphire influence	Militia, maritime militia, info and cyber
NDF (apolitical military)	To defend Omak's sovereignty without becoming a party tool	Fields the heavy equipment. Has red lines (§8).
Sapphire Party (ousted)	A comeback	**Not BLUEFOR.** Its loyalists are a small, white-cell-controlled fifth column that REDFOR may try to exploit.

4.3 Other actors (controlled by the white cell)

Actor	Alignment and capability	Interests and levers
Asotin	Peer adversary of Cosmopolis. **Backs the Omak government.** Similar in size, power, and capability to Cosmopolis, ~1,200 mi NW of Omak.	Wants a friendly Omak and a Strait that Cosmopolis doesn't control. Supplies arms, intel, and money. Avoids direct war with Cosmopolis unless provoked.
Tekoa	Neutral. Sparsely populated, mountainous, minimal government, heavily decentralized. Pirates, gangs, and local tribes.	Controls the north shore of the Strait and its airspace. Wants money, aid, and to keep the war off its soil. Can grant or deny overflight and mountain radar sites.
Latah	Sides with Cosmopolis. Modest military, good air bases.	Has granted logistics access but **not combat basing**. Worried about Omak retaliation and Asotin's reaction.
Camas	Sides with Cosmopolis. An island state with little military of its own. Hosts the CNDF forward air base.	Its population is nervous about being a target. Civilian casualties on Camas are a political flashpoint.
Pirates, gangs, tribes	None. Small boats, local knowledge.	Prey on shipping when the Strait is chaotic. Can be hired by anyone.
Shipping and markets	—	React to Strait Traffic: insurance rates, rerouting, price spikes
The press	—	The white cell's voice for consequences

How to use white-cell actors: you can argue a COA that tries to persuade, pay, or pressure them ("A diplomatic delegation persuades Latah to grant basing because..."). The white cell adjudicates it like any other COA.

5. Tracks

Tracks sit beside the map. COA results and their consequences move them.

Track	Range	Starts at	Moves when…	Trigger effects
Strait Traffic	Open / Restricted / Closed	**Open** before the war, **Restricted** once it starts	Mining, blockades, escorts, clearing, deals	**Closed:** −1 to Cosmopolis Domestic Will at the end of each turn it stays Closed
International Opinion	−3 (pro-Omak) … +3 (pro-Cosmopolis)	**−1** (meddling scandal)	Civilian harm, legitimacy actions, diplomacy, propaganda, broken deals	**+3:** Latah grants full combat basing automatically. **−3:** Asotin escalates its support.
Cosmopolis Domestic Will	0 … 5	**3**	Casualties, a Closed Strait, victories, information ops aimed at Cosmopolis	**≥ 4:** big REDFOR RFFs approved more readily. **0:** the legislature orders a ceasefire and negotiations.
Omak Regime Stability	0 … 5	**4** (supportive population)	Strikes on infrastructure, Sapphire unrest, rallying around the flag, NDF–PFA friction	**5:** S-B1 removed ("national unity"). **0:** the government collapses and the NDF takes over as caretaker.

6. Starting conditions

These are public. Both teams see them on cue cards. Use them in your Pros and Cons.
REDFOR: more assets, longer reach, more constraints

ID	Name	Effect	How to remove it
S-R1	**The 8,000-Mile Tail**	Reinforcements arrive slowly (§7). Camas can sustain high-tempo operations for **3 turns**. After that, −1 on Camas-based strike COAs until resupplied.	A successful resupply COA, or an RFF for a sustainment package
S-R2	**Single Hub**	All forward forces sit on Camas. A successful BLUEFOR strike on Camas affects **every** counter there, so one roll can Degrade several.	ACE dispersal: a **big project, 2 successful COAs** (e.g. Latah basing + an ACE package)
S-R3	**Latah Hesitates**	Latah allows logistics only. No combat sorties from Latah.	A successful diplomatic COA, or International Opinion reaches +3
S-R4	**Legitimacy Deficit**	International Opinion starts at −1. COAs that rely on third-party cooperation get −1 while Opinion ≤ −1.	Raise International Opinion to 0 or more

BLUEFOR: fewer assets, natural defender's advantages

ID	Name	Effect	How to remove it
S-B1	**A House Divided**	−1 on COAs that need NDF **and** PFA forces to work together	A successful "unified command" COA, or Regime Stability reaches 5
S-B2	**Sapphire Loyalists**	A small minority. REDFOR may argue for defections or sabotage, but such COAs take **−1** because of S-B5.	A successful counterintelligence COA removes the option entirely
S-B3	**Home Ground** *(advantage)*	**+1** to BLUEFOR **defensive** COAs in Omak zones (Z10–Z12): defending, dispersing, hiding, repairing, ambushing. Defenders know the terrain, and any ground incursion is very costly.	Permanent
S-B4	**Asotin's Backing** *(advantage)*	BLUEFOR requests for Asotin arms and intel are **routinely approved**. Bigger escalations need conditions. Supplies arrive via the West Approach and by air. REDFOR must argue a successful COA to interdict them, and interdiction risks Asotin escalation.	Permanent
S-B5	**Supportive Population** *(advantage)*	Regime Stability starts at 4. REDFOR COAs that rely on Omak civilians (SOF operating in Omak, loyalist uprisings, information ops aimed at Omak's public) take **−1**. BLUEFOR RFIs about REDFOR activity *inside Omak* get full answers (local lookouts).	Eroded: if Regime Stability falls to 2 or lower, the −1 no longer applies

7. Timing and movement

Each turn is about **3 days**. "N" is the turn an RFF is approved.

Movement	Takes
Any aircraft within theater (Camas ↔ Strait, Latah ↔ Strait)	Same turn (part of the COA)
Fighters, tankers, and ISR self-deploying from Cosmopolis	Arrive N+1
Bombers striking from Cosmopolis	Same turn, but the bomber counter is used up for that turn
Airlifted light ground forces	N+2
Naval forces from regional waters	N+2
Amphibious forces	N+3
Heavy ground forces by sea from Cosmopolis	**Beyond the game** (≥ 5 turns)
BLUEFOR ground forces within Omak (zone to adjacent zone)	Same turn
BLUEFOR mobilization	N+1
Asotin support	N+1 to N+3, depending on what is sent
Diplomatic results (basing agreements, recognition)	Same turn if the COA succeeds. Effects begin next turn.

8. Rules of Engagement (ROEs) and National Directives

These are public in the game world. The white cell may add, change, or lift directives during the game.

Cosmopolis (REDFOR)

1. No nuclear, chemical, or biological weapons (applies to every actor).
2. **No strikes on leadership or government targets in Omak City (Omak's capital)** without national authority (an RFF for authorities).
3. **No ground forces on Omak soil** without national approval.
4. **Respect Tekoan sovereignty:** no operations in Tekoan territory or airspace without Tekoa's consent.
5. **Do not engage Asotin forces or Asotin-flagged shipments** without national authority. Shipments that have already been delivered inside Omak are fair game.
6. Minimize civilian harm. A COA result causing significant civilian casualties moves International Opinion −1 **and** Domestic Will −1.

Omak (BLUEFOR)

1. The NDF chief's standing order: **the NDF will not fire on Omak civilians or take part in political repression.** Internal security is PFA-only.
2. Striking *civilian* targets on Camas or in Latah moves International Opinion **+1 (toward Cosmopolis)**, which hurts Omak. Striking **Latah** at all brings Latah into the war.
3. Attacking neutral shipping in the Strait (not Cosmopolis-flagged or military) moves International Opinion +1 (toward Cosmopolis).